



Strong show: Max Verstappen (left) mounted an unforgettable charge through the field to finish third, keeping himself firmly in title contention. AP

threat they would be coming under, but not young Kimi Antonelli (**above, right**). The Mercedes driver showed remarkable composure to fend off the Dutchman and secure a career-best second place. The tension between them melted away in a heartfelt post-race embrace.

For Antonelli, it was a defining result; for Verstappen, another testament to his fighting spirit. And for Norris, it was a statement win that all but reshaped the championship narrative, one that saw him playing catch-up a few weeks ago.

Uphill task

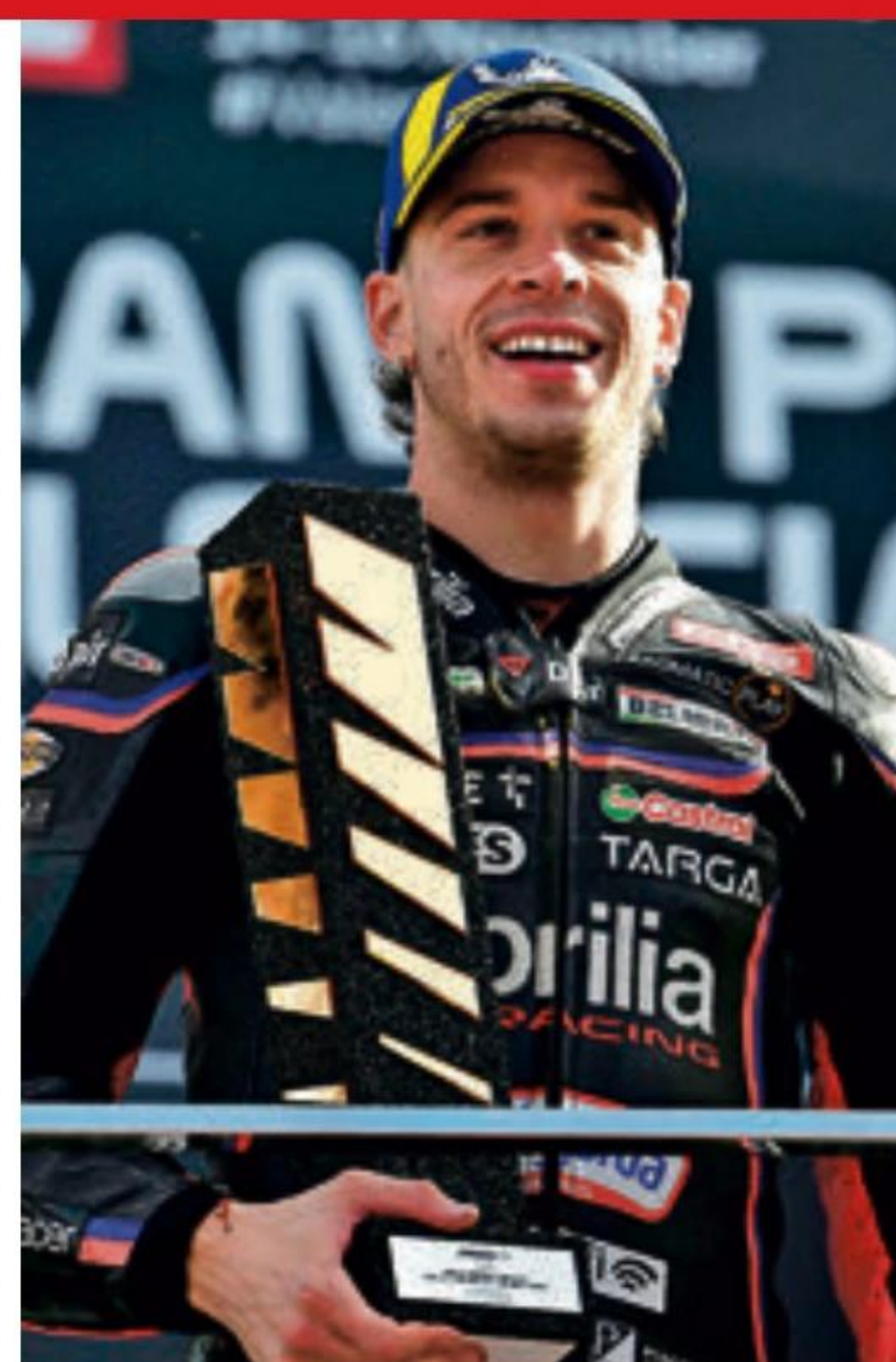
For Piastri, a bright start to the season has gradually faded since the weekend in Monza. The McLaren driver admitted that his mindset heading into Baku, the next event, wasn't ideal, shaped in part by the fallout from Italy, where team orders created friction within the garage.

Letting Norris through then has had lasting repercussions. Five races later, that decision seems to have snowballed into a string of frustrations. In Azerbaijan, an early crash compounded the pressure — the culmination of what Piastri

described as a “perfect storm” that disrupted both his rhythm and confidence. Since then, he has struggled to fully recover.

Heading into Brazil, he trailed Norris by just a single point, but a costly mistake in the sprint changed that. After hitting the wall early in the session, the gap grew to nine points, leaving Sunday as a potential turning point. Starting fourth kept him in the mix, but during a Safety Car restart, Piastri took a bold lunge on Antonelli, and the move backfired. The two made contact, sending Antonelli into Charles Leclerc, who was attempting to pass around the outside. The collision ended the Ferrari driver's race and earned Piastri a debated 10-second penalty.

He recovered to finish fifth, having last stood on the podium five races ago. But Piastri knew that the result was nowhere near enough. With just three Grand Prix races and one sprint remaining, the 24-year-old needs to rediscover his early-season form and perhaps rely on a touch of fortune if he hopes to catch Norris and keep the championship fight alive.



REUTERS

MotoGP

Aprilia rider Marco Bezzecchi (**in pics**) closed out the 2025 MotoGP season with back-to-back statement wins to cap a fine end to his year.

At the concluding Valencia round, the 27-year-old sealed third place in the championship in the sprint and edged out Raul Fernandez in the main race to celebrate in style. Bezzecchi also triumphed the previous weekend in Portugal as Aprilia sealed back-to-back Grand Prix victories for the first time. The Italian's third place also gave Aprilia its first top-three championship finish.

While Marc Marquez had clinched his seventh world title with five events to spare in Japan in September, his brother Alex sealed second place overall in October, wrapping up a memorable year for Ducati and the Marquez family.

